



# Scapolite

△ Fine, oval, brilliant-cut yellow scapolite gem

Originally believed to be a single mineral, scapolite is the name now given to a group of minerals related by structure, and it is still used in the gemstone trade to refer to any members of the scapolite mineral group cut as gemstones. It is distinctly pleochroic and stones vary in colour when viewed from different angles – violet stones appear dark or light blue, and violet and yellow stones appear pale yellow and colourless. Some scapolites cut *en cabochon* show signs of chatoyancy, a streak of light in the form of a cat's eye.

## Specification

**Chemical name** Sodium, calcium silicate chloride or sulphate  
**Formula**  $\text{Na}_4(\text{Al}_3\text{Si}_9\text{O}_{24})\text{Cl} - \text{Ca}_4(\text{Al}_6\text{Si}_6\text{O}_{24})(\text{CO}_3\text{SO}_4)$  | **Colours** Colourless, white, grey, yellow, orange, pink | **Structure** Tetragonal  
**Hardness** 5–6 | **SG** 2.5–2.7 | **RI** 1.54–1.58 | **Lustre** Vitreous  
**Streak** White | **Locations** Myanmar, Canada, USA, Tanzania



**Scapolite crystals | Rough** | The hollow in this rock groundmass is filled with a cluster of numerous prismatic scapolite crystals, each with four sides of similar length.

Rock groundmass

Blue scapolite



**Blue crystals | Rough** | Scapolite comes in a number of colours, but usually forms in metamorphic rocks. These pale, almost translucent, blue crystals are prismatic.



Mineral inclusions

**Scapolite cabochon | Cut** | This highly polished cabochon displays a hazy purple-violet colouring and features visible mineral inclusions.



**Cushion-cut gemstone | Colour variety** | This cushion-cut scapolite stone is notable for its deep brownish-purple colouring. It weighs 2.95 carats.



**Mixed-cut scapolite | Cut** | This beautifully clear example of colourless scapolite is given a striking brilliance by the many facets of its unusual mixed cut.



**Museum quality | Cut** | This 113-carat, yellow, pear-shaped scapolite (shown actual size) is of exceptional clarity and brilliance, and would grace any museum collection.



**Scapolite earrings | Set** | These delicate 18-karat gold earrings are carved from frosted rock crystal, and crowned with pear-shaped, faceted blue scapolites.